

10 Questions to Ask Before Choosing a Secondary School

Choosing the right school is one of the biggest decisions of the journey. Here are the questions that matter most.

There is so much to weigh when choosing a secondary school, and open evenings can leave you dazzled rather than clear. This checklist cuts through the noise.

Take it with you to open days and tours. The answers, and how a school responds to being asked, tell you a great deal. Green notes flag what matters especially for **grammar schools**.

1

Does the school's ethos match my child and our family?

Every school has a character, academic and high-pressure, nurturing and pastoral, faith-based, creative. The best school on paper is not always the best school for *your* child.

Ask: What are your core values, and how do they show up in daily school life?

Grammar note: Highly academic environments suit some children and overwhelm others. Be honest about which yours is.

2

What are the admissions criteria, and can my child meet them?

Understand exactly how places are allocated before you pin your hopes on a school, the entrance test, the pass mark, catchment, and the order of priority for places.

Ask: What is the admissions process, and how are places prioritised if the school is oversubscribed?

Grammar note: Check the qualifying standard, catchment, and whether it runs its own test or a shared one. Read the school's own admissions policy, not third-party sites.

3

What is the school's academic record, honestly?

Look beyond the headline league-table position. How do students actually progress, and how does the school stretch the more able while supporting those who need it?

Ask: How do your results compare over recent years, and how do you support both advanced and struggling students?

Grammar note: In a selective school every child was "top" at primary. Ask how they help children adjust to no longer being the highest in the room.

4

How does the school support wellbeing and mental health?

Pastoral care matters as much as academics, arguably more at secondary age. A child who feels safe and known will thrive; one who does not, won't, however good the teaching.

Ask: What pastoral and mental-health support is in place, and who would my child turn to on a hard day?

Grammar note: Academic pressure can be intense. Ask specifically how they protect wellbeing alongside high expectations.

5

What is the culture around behaviour, belonging and bullying?

The everyday atmosphere shapes your child's happiness daily. Ask how the school handles discipline, builds community, and deals with bullying when it happens, because it happens everywhere.

Ask: How do you handle behaviour and bullying, and how do you help every child feel they belong?

6

What are the teachers and teaching like?

Teachers make the school. Consider their experience, how supported they are, and, tellingly, staff turnover, high turnover can signal deeper problems.

Ask: What is your staff turnover like, and how accessible are teachers to parents about a child's progress?

7

What is on offer beyond the classroom?

Clubs, sport, music, drama, leadership, trips, this is where children discover who they are and find their people. A rich wider life is a sign of a healthy school.

Ask: What extracurricular opportunities are there, and how many children genuinely take part?

Grammar note: Make sure a strong academic focus hasn't crowded out the arts, sport and play your child needs.

8

How does the school communicate with, and involve, parents?

You are your child's advocate for the next seven years. You want a school that keeps you informed and takes your concerns seriously, not one that goes quiet when you have a question.

Ask: How will you keep me informed, and how are parent concerns handled?

9

Is it practical, journey, hours, and daily logistics?

A brilliant school with a punishing two-hour round trip can wear a child down. Weigh the commute, transport, start and finish times, and how it fits your family's real life.

Ask: What does a typical school day look like, and what are the transport options?

Grammar note: Grammar schools often draw from a wide area, so the journey can be long. Be realistic about it for the years ahead.

10

Where do the children go next, and what do families say?

A school's leavers and its reputation among current families tell you what the glossy prospectus won't. Look at destinations, and listen to parents who are actually there.

Ask: Where do your leavers typically go, and may I speak with current parents?

Trust the answers, and trust your instinct.

You know your child better than any league table ever could.

Weighing up schools and want to think it through with others? Come and share where you are with parents walking the same path.

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Choose with your head and your heart. ♥

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